then have a much better sense of what it means to extend the radius of operation of a BC. And if the deputy governor also visits villages in the North-east, she will be able to appreciate why the area of operation there should be different from that in the rest of the country.

Whenever I went to see the prime minister, I would often tell him about the various initiatives of the Reserve Bank towards financial inclusion and how the technology of a handheld machine was proving to be a game changer in barefoot banking. I also used to urge him, during his travels across the country, to just side step into a village, any village, to see a BC in operation. He and I, both knew that this was not a practical idea. The prime minister's travels are so well choreographed and the security so intense that it is virtually impossible for him to make an impromptu visit to a village. In the event, we settled for the second-best alternative. I offered to bring a BC to his office and demonstrate the operation to him.

Anyone who has seen a BC operating a handheld machine, which is just like a credit card reader, would have noticed that the technology is far from robust. Because the palms of villagers are typically soiled, it takes several attempts to get the machine to respond to their fingerprints. In the manner of learning by doing, BCs acquire rich experience in making these stubborn machines work. Given this situation, it would have been best for us to choose a couple of BCs from the vast hinterland of the country for the demonstration before the prime minister. But that wasn't to be. Demonstrating barefoot banking before the prime minister was such a rare and prized opportunity that the chairmen of public sector banks offered their own services.

So it transpired that one afternoon in September 2010, deputy governors Usha Thorat and K.C. Chakrabarty, O.P. Bhat, chairman of State Bank of India, and K.R. Kamath, chairman of Punjab National Bank, and I, along with three villagers, appeared at the 7 Race Course Road residence of the prime minister to give him a demonstration of the handheld mission. Imagine the situation. None among the five of us had any prior experience of touching a handheld machine, let alone operating it. I am sure both Bhat